century, but it did not necessarily reflect a long or lasting political cohesiveness. [2]

Another misleading notion is of India traditionally being a strategic backwater, ‘a world apart’ as a prominent American statesman once mischaracterized the subcontinent. [3] Instead, the history of India’s international relations shows lengthy and—in some cases—extensive links with West Asia (the Middle East), the Mediterranean, Central Asia, Southeast Asia, China, Europe, Africa, and subsequently even the Americas. Over the centuries, India was of great interest to outsiders, whether travellers, conquerors, traders, or missionaries—from Alexander of Macedon and Faxian to Ibn Battuta and Vasco da Gama. Additionally, India, in turn, was shaped by competing international orders, and perhaps just as importantly left strong imprints around the world that are not always appreciated today. At times, India straddled various global systems, such as between East Africa and Southeast Asia in the Indian Ocean basin or between the Islamic world and China across Central Asia along what was later termed the Silk Road. In fact, international politics were a persistent feature of Indian history from its earliest days.

This seemingly ancient history remains important for a few reasons. One, it reinforces the timelessness of international politics as an ultimately competitive enterprise, in which outcomes are determined by power and security. Two, it shows the wide extent of international commerce and the perils of isolationism. The rest of the world has taken an interest in India, even during periods when India has chosen to retreat into itself. In turn, questions of power and trade hold important lessons for the security of the Indian Ocean, as India’s colonial experience in the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries made clear. Finally, the long view of history reminds contemporary readers of the importance of defining and shaping international norms. The ideological crosscurrents throughout Indian history —whether Hindu, Persian, Hellenistic, Buddhist, Islamic, Chinese, or European—are relevant to defining and contesting contemporary international values and ideas.